KARLSRUHE, GERMANY

Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings in which an obstacle, an edge or an overlapping form changes how space is read.



A view of the sea need not give the sea most of the room. In Cézanne's L'Estaque painting, foreground trees and ground remain assertive, partly blocking the expected prospect. That refusal to clear a path has counterparts elsewhere in this selection: Grünewald's cross obstructs a crowd, Ernst's forest resists easy passage, and Beckmann's still-life objects press into a shallow space.

Other pictures offer more orderly routes. Streets, gardens and river crossings permit comparisons between openness and congestion. The aim is not to impose one historical development on these works, but to notice the different demands a picture makes before allowing its subject to become easily readable.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/kunsthalle-karlsruhe

The selection · 20

1. Forest
   Max Ernst · 1927
2. Tauberbischofsheim Altarpiece: Crucifixion
   Matthias Grünewald · 1523–1524
3. Poverty and Care
   Arnold Böcklin · 1890
4. Tauberbischofsheim Altarpiece: Christ Carrying the Cross
   Matthias Grünewald · 1523–1524
5. At the Morning Toilet
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6. Improvisation 13
   Wassily Kandinsky · 1910
7. Still Life with a Fallen Candle
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8. Madame Jeantaud
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9. The Three Daughters of Julius Johann von Vieth und Golssenau
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10. Rocky Reef on the Seashore
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11. View of Karlsruhe from the South
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13. View of the Sea at L'Estaque
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14. The Great Bridge at Rouen in Rainy Weather
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15. The Seine at Rouen
    Claude Monet · 1874
16. Cupid as a Honey Thief
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17. The Decameron
    Franz Xaver Winterhalter · 1837
18. Still Life with Oranges, Bananas, Lemon and Tomato
    Paula Modersohn-Becker · 1906
19. The Founding of Constantinople
    Peter Paul Rubens · c. 1622-1623
20. Houses at Le Pouldu
    Paul Gauguin · 1890

01 / 20

Forest

Max Ernst

1927 · Oil on canvas · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Max Ernst. Forest. WikiArt source label: Max Ernst Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/max-ernst/forest-1927 · Max Ernst Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The vertical forms can suggest trunks, yet their dense, jagged surfaces also resemble rough construction. A red arc introduces another scale above them. Ernst keeps enough repetition to establish a forest without making its parts comfortably familiar. The image offers recognition at the level of the whole while resisting it in the individual forms.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Tauberbischofsheim Altarpiece: Crucifixion

Matthias Grünewald

1523–1524 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Matthias Grünewald. Tauberbischofsheim altarpiece: Christ on the Cross with Mary and Saint John. Image credit: Matthias Grünewald; Source credit: 1. The Yorck Project (2002) 10.000 Meisterwerke der Malerei (DVD-ROM), distributed by DIRECTMEDIA Publishing GmbH. ISBN : 3936122202 . 2. Google Art Project. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Christ's strained outline occupies the panel with little surrounding relief. Below, Mary and John answer the crucified body through their gestures rather than through an elaborate setting. Grünewald makes bodily detail carry the scene's severity. The restricted dark space does not explain suffering; it leaves the extended arms and the mourners' positions difficult to overlook.

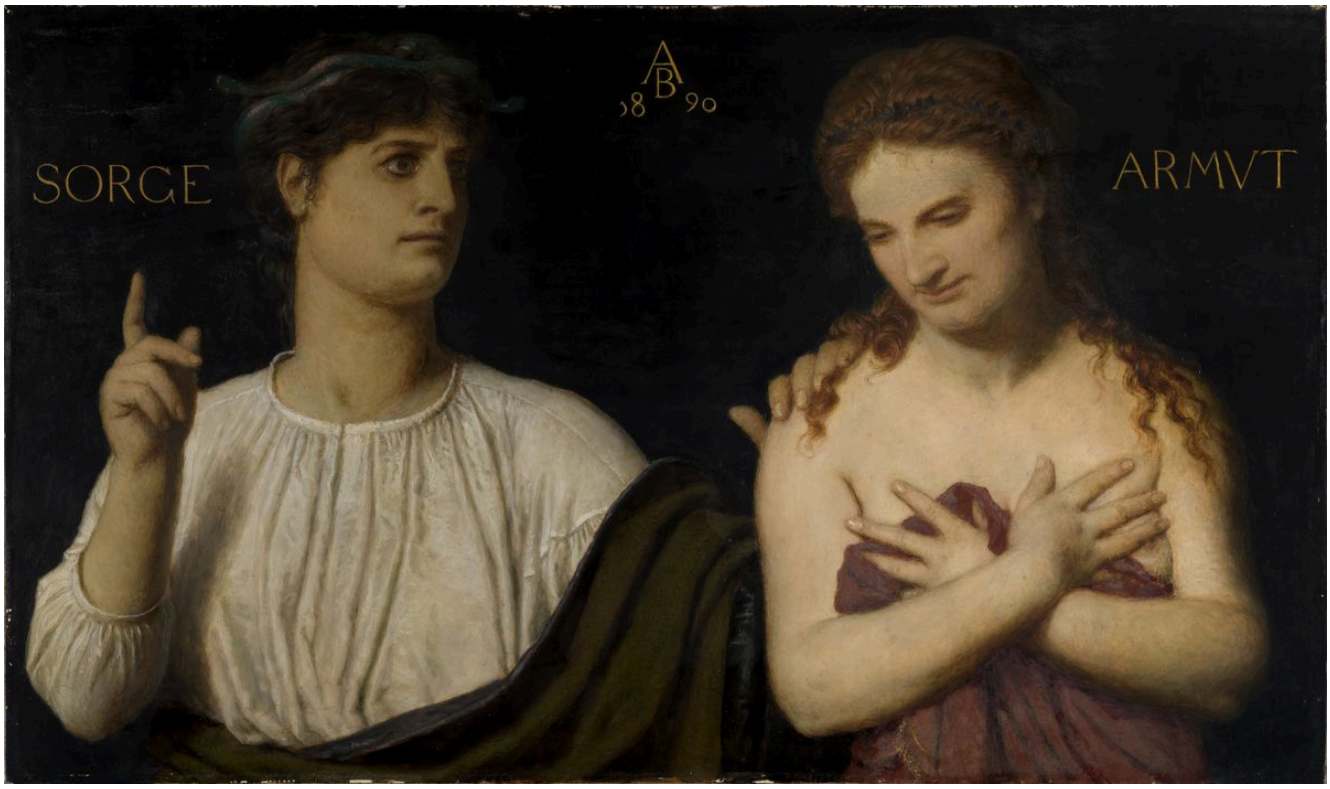
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 994

03 / 20

Poverty and Care

Arnold Böcklin

1890 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Arnold Böcklin. Armut und Sorge. Image credit: Arnold Böcklin; Source credit: Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe, Sammlung online. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

One raised finger and another figure's folded arms supply different bodily attitudes within the close pairing. The title asks that the women be read as personifications, not simply unnamed sitters. Böcklin gives abstract conditions human form, but their labels do not erase the gestures. The picture depends on the distance between a concept and a particular pose.

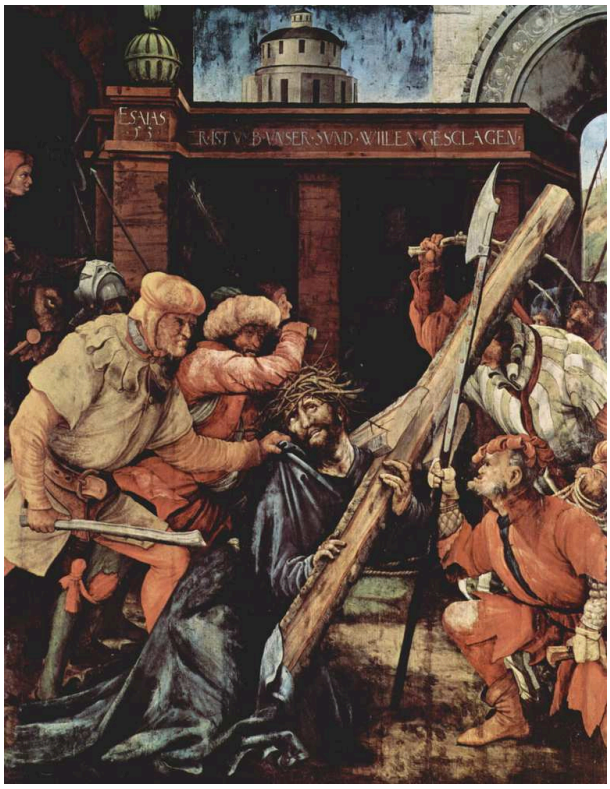
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 958

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Tauberbischofsheim Altarpiece: Christ Carrying the Cross

Matthias Grünewald

1523–1524 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Matthias Grünewald. Tauberbischofsheim altarpiece: Christ Carrying the Cross. Image credit: Matthias Grünewald; Source credit: The Yorck Project (2002) 10.000 Meisterwerke der Malerei (DVD-ROM), distributed by DIRECTMEDIA Publishing GmbH. ISBN : 3936122202 .. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The cross is a burden and an obstruction. Its diagonal timber cuts through the crowded group beneath the architectural opening, preventing an easy separation of the figures. Compared with the Crucifixion panel, this scene makes suffering congested and mobile. Christ's bent body has to negotiate a space already occupied by other bodies and the immense load.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 993

05 / 20

At the Morning Toilet

Justus Juncker

1752 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Justus Juncker. At the morning toilet. Image credit: Justus Juncker; Source credit: Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The mirror places grooming inside a room already full of other images. Tiles, furniture and wall pictures order the interior around an ordinary routine. Juncker does not isolate the seated woman from her environment; the act belongs to a furnished life. Looking at oneself becomes one form of looking among several that the room accommodates.

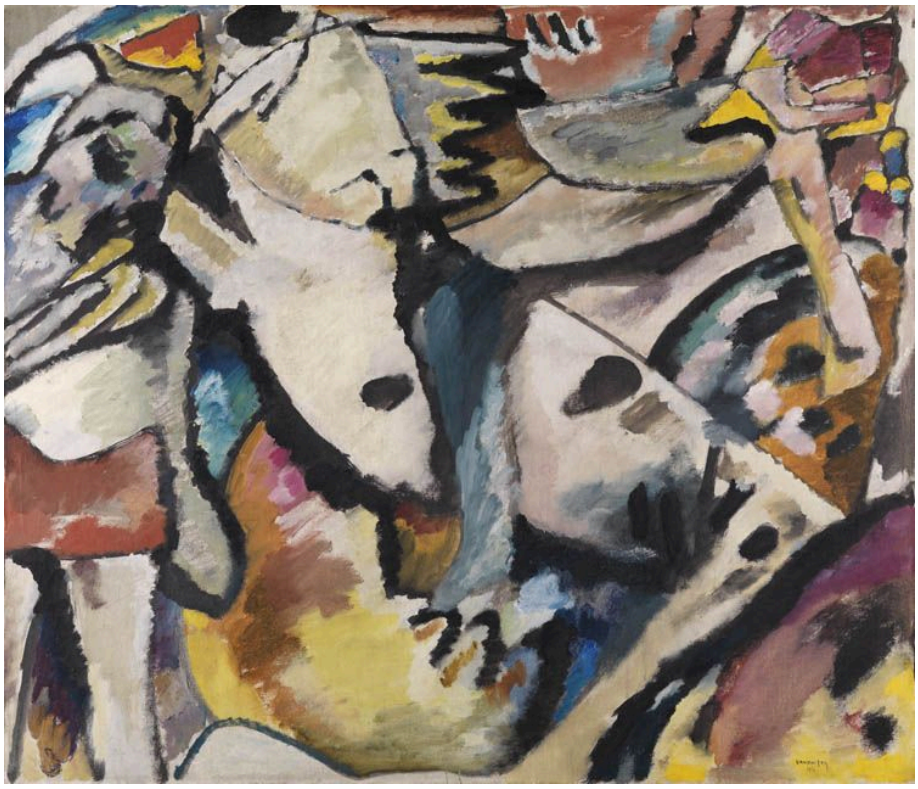
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2506

06 / 20

Improvisation 13

Wassily Kandinsky

1910 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Wassily Kandinsky. Improvisation 13. Image credit: Wassily Kandinsky. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Some contours suggest bodies or terrain, but they do not assemble into one dependable scene. Kandinsky allows the coloured patches and crossing black marks to establish relationships independently. Recognition can start and stop without bringing the picture to a halt. Its organisation does not depend on converting every area into a named object.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2596

07 / 20

Still Life with a Fallen Candle

Max Beckmann

1930 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Max Beckmann. Still life with fallen candle. Image credit: Max Beckmann; Source credit: https://www.kunsthalle-karlsruhe.de/kunstwerke/Max-Beckmann/Stilleben-mit-gest%C3%BCrzter-Kerze/A1C925EE4DA39411535E9298B95C5E13/. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The fallen element introduces a horizontal interruption among objects gathered in a compressed space. Strong contours make their proximity conspicuous. Beckmann's drapery and framed surface add layers without producing much room to move between them. The still life is nominally motionless, yet its relations suggest an order that has been disturbed rather than serenely completed.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2435

08 / 20

Madame Jeantaud

Edgar Degas

c. 1877 · Oil on canvas · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Edgar Degas, Bildnis Madame Jeantaud, c.1877. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. CC0 1.0. Resized and JPEG-compressed; no crop or retouching. CC0 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The extended arm makes the sofa part of the pose. Dark clothing rises against its pale surface, while the hat and upright torso provide another direction. Degas obtains movement from asymmetry rather than overt action. The furniture does not merely indicate a comfortable room; it helps determine how the sitter occupies the picture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2493

09 / 20

The Three Daughters of Julius Johann von Vieth und Golssenau

Anton Graff

c. 1773 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Anton Graff. Bildnis der drei Töchter von Julius Johann von Vieth und Golssenau. Image credit: Anton Graff; Source credit: Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The sisters lean into a compact group, with hands and inclining heads joining their separate likenesses. Graff avoids the regularity of three portraits placed side by side. Small differences of tilt and contact keep the figures distinct while the dark background allows their pale faces to share a close outline. Togetherness is constructed without exact symmetry.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Lg 1913

10 / 20

Rocky Reef on the Seashore

Caspar David Friedrich

1824 · Oil on canvas · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Caspar David Friedrich, Felsenriff am Meeresstrand, 1824. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. CC0 1.0. Resized and JPEG-compressed; no crop or retouching. CC0 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

No human figure supplies a response to the shore. A sharp distant silhouette rises above lower spreading rocks and pools, giving the landscape its own contrast of vertical and horizontal force. Friedrich leaves those relations exposed beneath the violet-blue sky. The absence of a spectator within the painting keeps its mood from being assigned through someone else's expression.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2261

11 / 20

View of Karlsruhe from the South

Carl Kuntz

1804 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Carl Kuntz. Blick auf Karlsruhe von Süden. Image credit: Carl Kuntz; Source credit: 1. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe 2. Google Arts & Culture. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The city is approached across fields and animals rather than introduced by a close architectural landmark. Tall trees and a broad sky make the settlement part of a larger worked landscape. Kuntz's distance gives agriculture a substantial foreground presence. The urban view includes the land around the city instead of treating it as empty approach space.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1715

12 / 20

Karlsruhe Palace from the Palace Garden

Carl Kuntz

1804 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Carl Kuntz. Blick auf das Karlsruher Schloss vom Schlossgarten aus. Image credit: Carl Kuntz; Source credit: 1. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe 2. Google Arts & Culture. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Lawns, trees and small groups of animals soften the approach to the palace. Formal architecture remains distinct, but it is encountered through open grounds rather than in isolation. Beside Kuntz's southern city view, the picture reveals a different way of presenting the same place: here the palace organises the prospect without occupying the entire foreground.

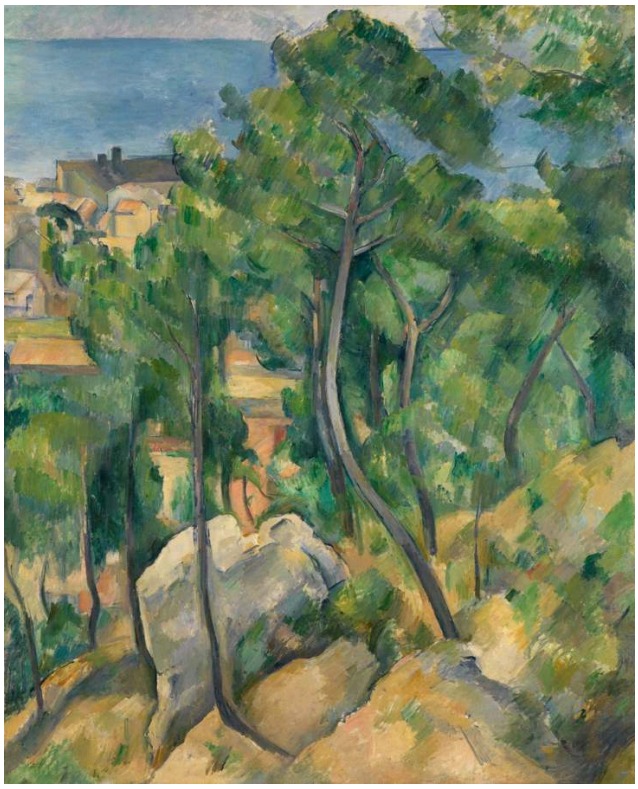
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1964

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View of the Sea at L'Estaque

Paul Cézanne

1883-1885 · Oil on canvas · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Paul Cézanne, Blick auf das Meer bei L'Estaque, 1883–1885. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. CC0 1.0. Resized and JPEG-compressed; no crop or retouching. CC0 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Trees and sloping ground obstruct a view the title seems to promise. Cézanne makes those near forms structurally important through adjoining areas of green, blue and ochre. The sea is one part of an interdependent arrangement, not a reward waiting beyond disposable foreground scenery. Depth is negotiated through colour relationships as well as recognisable objects.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2450

14 / 20

The Great Bridge at Rouen in Rainy Weather

Camille Pissarro

1896 · Oil on canvas · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Camille Pissarro, Blick auf die Grosse Brücke zu Rouen bei Regenstimmung, 1896. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. CC0 1.0. Resized and JPEG-compressed; no crop or retouching. CC0 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

From this high viewpoint, bridges reveal connections that would be harder to follow at street level. Small people, vehicles and river traffic occupy the structure beneath a heavy sky. Pissarro allows rainy conditions to affect a working city without dissolving its routes. Weather and organised movement remain simultaneous parts of the view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2488

15 / 20

The Seine at Rouen

Claude Monet

1874 · Oil on canvas · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Claude Monet, Die Seine bei Rouen, 1874. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. CC0 1.0. Resized and JPEG-compressed; no crop or retouching. CC0 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The masts offer firm verticals against the broken water and sky. Below them, short marks make reflections less dependable than the vessels they recall. Monet preserves the port through that difference. Solid structures and shifting light do not have to be painted with the same degree of stability for the scene to hold together.

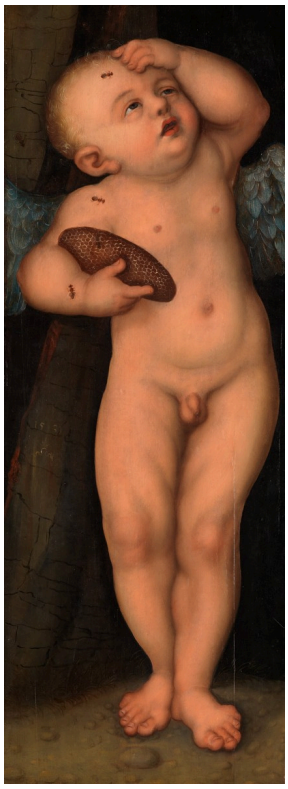
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2502

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Cupid as a Honey Thief

Lucas Cranach the Elder

1531 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Lucas Cranach the Elder. Cupid as Honey Thief. Image credit: Workshop of Lucas Cranach the Elder / After Lucas Cranach the Elder; Source credit: 1./2. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe, digitale Sammlung 3. Google Arts & Culture. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The honeycomb promises sweetness, while the bees make its cost visible. Cupid's lifted hand turns the small body into an image of discomfort. Cranach concentrates the episode in a narrow space with little competing incident. The lesson attached to desire is carried by a specific physical consequence rather than by an abstract inscription alone.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 811

17 / 20

The Decameron

Franz Xaver Winterhalter

1837 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Der Decamerone. Franz Xaver Winterhalter; Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression. · CC0

The literary title introduces storytelling, but Winterhalter gives much of the picture to the company assembled around it. Varied poses and elaborate clothes make listeners as visible as any speaking figure. The garden supports this collective leisure. A story can organise a group without its particular words becoming recoverable from the painted gathering.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1217

18 / 20

Still Life with Oranges, Bananas, Lemon and Tomato

Paula Modersohn-Becker

1906 · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Paula Modersohn-Becker. Stilleben mit Orangen, Bananen, Zitrone und Tomate. Image credit: Paula Modersohn-Becker; Source credit: Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Simplified colour gives the fruit substantial volume without a catalogue of surface details. Rounded bodies meet pale cloth and the dish within a close tabletop arrangement. Modersohn-Becker makes weight a relation between shapes. The objects need not be luxurious or botanically elaborate for their placement to sustain attention.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2557

19 / 20

The Founding of Constantinople

Peter Paul Rubens

c. 1622-1623 · Oil on oak · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Peter Paul Rubens, Die Gründung Konstantinopels, c.1622–1623. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. CC0 1.0. Resized and JPEG-compressed; no crop or retouching. CC0 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The ruler's gesture connects command to the work of construction. Other bodies carry the action across the scene beneath the broad sky and eagle. Rubens condenses a city's foundation into a coordinated group rather than a complete account of building. Authority becomes visible through the direction of activity, not simply through the central figure's costume.

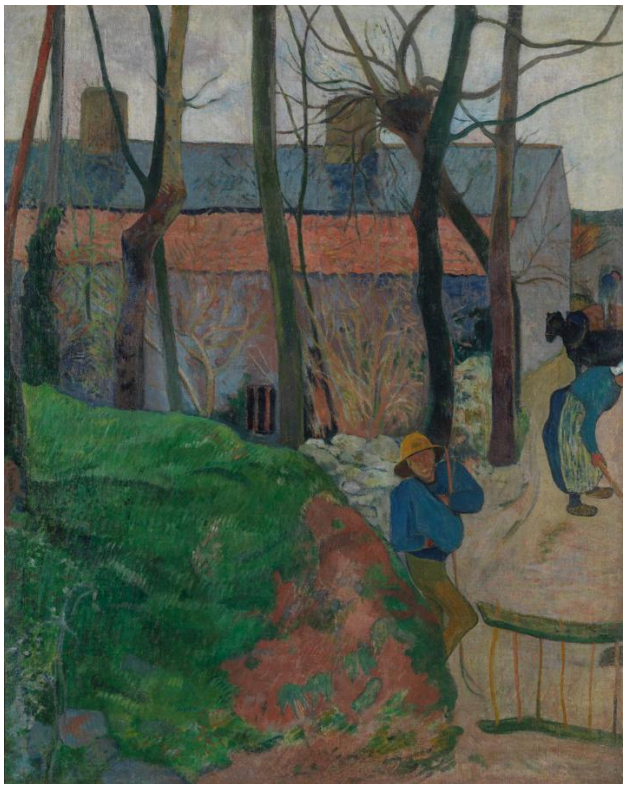
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2759

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Houses at Le Pouldu

Paul Gauguin

1890 · Oil on canvas · Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe



Paul Gauguin, Häuser in Le Pouldu, 1890. Staatliche Kunsthalle Karlsruhe. CC0 1.0. Resized and JPEG-compressed; no crop or retouching. CC0 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Bare trunks interrupt the coloured houses and divide the narrow intervals occupied by small figures. Gauguin allows these obstructions to contribute to a pattern of interlocking surfaces. The village remains identifiable, but deep continuous space is no longer the only organising goal. Foreground and buildings press towards a shared arrangement of colour.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2503

Two useful comparisons

Place the two Rouen views together, then compare Kuntz's two approaches to Karlsruhe. A changed viewpoint can be as consequential as a changed subject. For a visit, consult the museum's current venues and object availability; the selection is not a room-by-room route.

Further reading

Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by Michael Sadleir · Read free · English

Kandinsky’s book explains his search for meaning in colour and nonliteral form. Improvisation 13 provides a direct work against which to test those arguments, with the surrounding paintings offering other uses of colour.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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